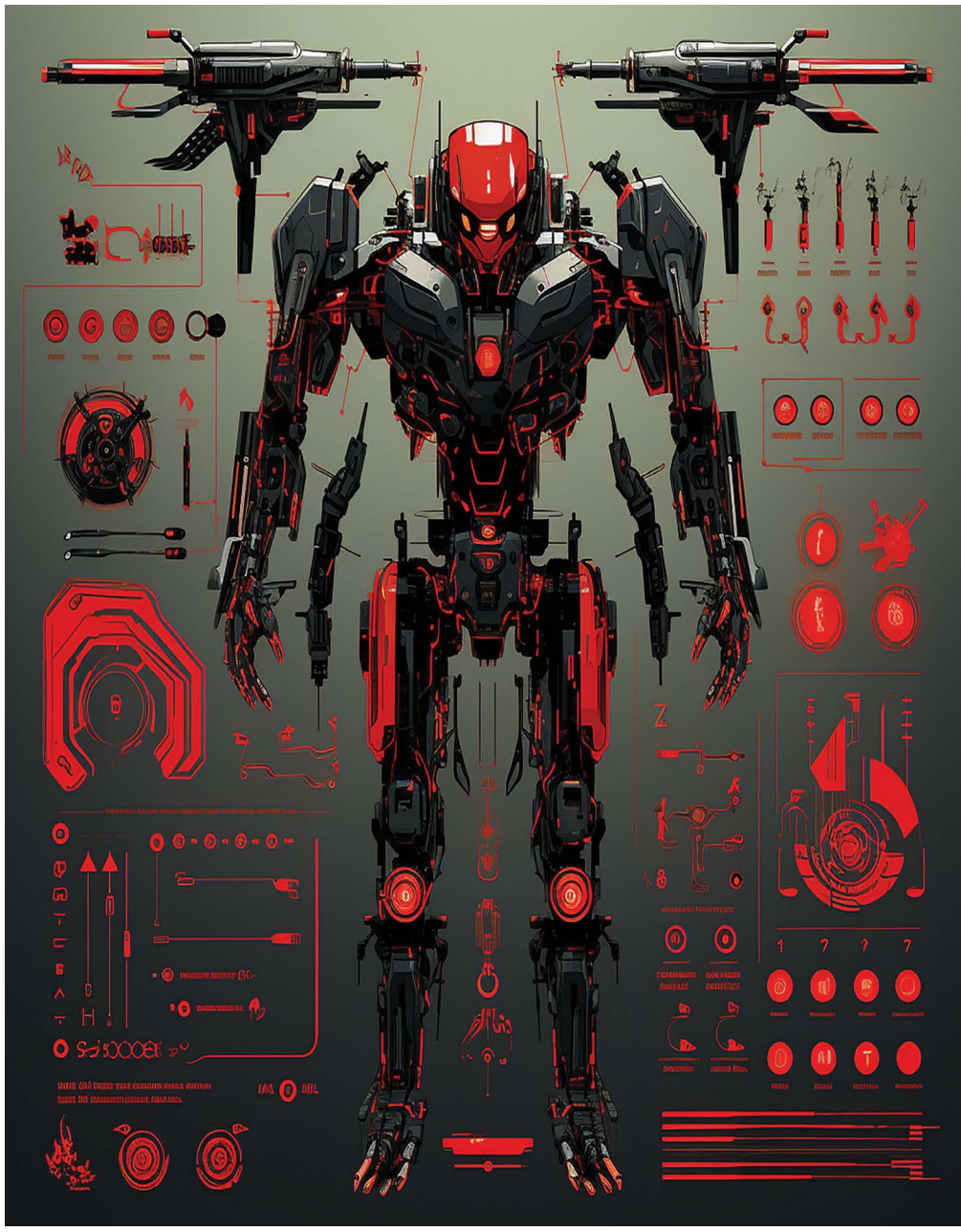


Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS** / AI

TAKEAWAYS

AI can be used to enhance decision-making, logistics, cybersecurity, surveillance and training

But inadvertent inclusion of biases into military AI could be disastrous

There is a need to have international conventions governing the use of AI for military purposes

ent matter altogether. If being used in a purely defensive mode, say, to strike down incoming missiles, like the Iron Dome of Israel, it could be autonomous and an acceptable use of AI.

However, much more thought will have to be given to its use against human targets. AI by itself is not foolproof and is subject to biases, inserted by accident or design. AI-based algorithms being used by many companies for recruitment or healthcare showed clear biases based on gender, race and even accent.

The inadvertent inclusion of biases into military AI could be disastrous. Moreover, we have not yet reached the stage where human emotions like empathy or compassion could be factored in—an Emotional AI. AI will and must be used in military systems, especially if it is going to reduce collateral damage and shorten conflict. But once again, what constitutes acceptable collateral damage is open to interpretation, as evidenced in the conflict in Gaza. With the development of AI for military use, there is a need to have international conventions governing the use of AI on the lines of the Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons. One key feature of such a convention should be the obligation to have a human in the loop who bears the moral responsibility of the final decision. The 'Stop Killer Robots' campaign seeks to do just that, calling for a law to regulate the degree of freedom given to AI-backed weapon systems. India is taking significant steps to integrate AI into its armed forces. However, it must be used ethically and responsibly. At the end of the day, the taking of human life cannot be relegated to an algorithm. ■